Sahaj Bhadja
Job Control Number: JC-519717
Statement of Qualifications

1. Please provide a specific example in which you had to investigate a potential security incident. What was the outcome of the incident, and how did collaboration and communication affect the result of the incident (if at all)?

During my tenure as a Security Analyst Intern at LST Capital, I was responsible for investigating suspicious emails and potential security threats targeting our financial systems. One significant incident involved a series of phishing emails that were reported by multiple employees across different departments. The emails appeared to originate from a trusted vendor and contained links to a credential harvesting site designed to steal employee login credentials.

Upon receiving the initial reports, I immediately began my investigation by analyzing the email headers and examining security logs using SQL queries to identify the scope of the threat. I queried our email gateway logs to determine how many employees had received similar emails and cross-referenced this data with our authentication logs to check for any successful credential compromises. My analysis revealed that approximately 35 employees had received the phishing emails, and fortunately, only two had clicked on the malicious links.

Collaboration and communication played a critical role in the successful resolution of this incident. I immediately escalated my initial findings to the Chief Information Security Officer and IT management, providing a clear summary of the threat scope and potential impact. Working closely with the IT team, we quickly blocked the malicious domain at the firewall level and implemented additional email filtering rules to prevent similar emails from reaching employee inboxes.

I coordinated with our Human Resources and Communications teams to draft an urgent security awareness notification that was sent to all employees within two hours of the incident discovery. This notification explained the threat, provided guidance on identifying similar phishing attempts, and instructed the two affected employees to immediately reset their credentials. I also worked with our vendor management team to verify the legitimacy of the supposed sender and confirm that their email systems had not been compromised.

The outcome of this incident was highly positive. Through effective collaboration and timely communication, we contained the threat before any data breach or financial loss occurred. The two employees who clicked the links had their credentials reset within 30 minutes of identification, and no unauthorized access to sensitive financial systems was detected. Following this incident, I developed documentation for our incident response procedures and created a security awareness training module on phishing identification, which was subsequently delivered to all staff members. This experience reinforced my understanding that successful incident response depends not only on technical analysis skills but equally on the ability to communicate effectively with stakeholders at all levels and coordinate across multiple teams to achieve rapid containment and resolution.

2. How would you prioritize competing requests from key stakeholders? Please explain your process and the potential impacts that may arise due to your decision.

In my experience working across multiple organizations, I have developed a systematic approach

to prioritizing competing requests from key stakeholders that balances urgency, impact, and organizational objectives while maintaining transparent communication with all parties involved.

My prioritization process follows a structured framework that I apply consistently:

Step 1: Assess Risk and Impact. I first evaluate each request based on its potential security risk and business impact. Requests involving active security threats, compliance deadlines, or potential data breaches receive immediate priority regardless of the stakeholder's position. For example, a request to investigate suspicious network activity would take precedence over a routine security policy review, even if the latter came from a more senior stakeholder.

Step 2: Evaluate Urgency and Dependencies. I determine whether requests have hard deadlines, regulatory requirements, or dependencies that affect other projects or teams. A security assessment required for an upcoming audit would be prioritized over an enhancement request with flexible timing. I also consider whether delaying certain requests could create bottlenecks for other critical work.

Step 3: Align with Organizational Objectives. I consider how each request aligns with the department's mission and strategic priorities. At the California Military Department, this would mean prioritizing requests that directly support mission-critical operations, protect sensitive information, or ensure compliance with applicable regulations.

Step 4: Communicate Transparently. Once I have established priorities, I communicate my assessment and proposed timeline to all affected stakeholders. I explain my reasoning clearly and provide realistic expectations for when their requests will be addressed. This transparency helps stakeholders understand the rationale behind prioritization decisions and reduces potential friction.

Step 5: Document and Escalate When Necessary. If conflicts cannot be resolved through my standard prioritization process, I escalate to my supervisor with a clear summary of the competing requests, my assessment, and a recommended course of action. I document all prioritization decisions to maintain accountability and support future decision-making.

The potential impacts of prioritization decisions can be significant. Correctly prioritizing a critical security request can prevent data breaches, protect organizational reputation, and ensure regulatory compliance. However, I recognize that deprioritized requests may cause delays for other teams or stakeholders, potentially affecting their projects or operations. To mitigate negative impacts, I proactively communicate expected timelines, offer interim solutions when possible, and regularly reassess priorities as circumstances change. I also maintain flexibility to adjust priorities when new information emerges or when organizational needs shift. This balanced approach ensures that the most critical security needs are addressed while maintaining positive working relationships with all stakeholders and supporting the overall mission of the organization.